

Lincoln's frustration

Frustrated with McClellan, Lincoln handed the primary eastern field command to General John Pope, who was promptly crushed by Lee at Second Bull Run. Lincoln had no choice but to turn to McClellan to rally the Union Army against a Confederate invasion of Maryland. But despite his early capture of Lee's campaign plan and a numerical superiority of around two to one, McClellan failed to destroy Lee's army at the Battle of Antietam (Sharpsburg) on September 17, 1862. However, he did force Lee to retreat back to Virginia.

Lincoln used the "victory" at Antietam to issue the Preliminary Emancipation Proclamation and, finally losing patience with McClellan's lethargic military movements, relieved him of his post on November 5. The general then ran for president on the Democratic ticket in 1864, attempting to balance his Unionist convictions with the radical peace platform of some Northern Democrats. Lincoln won an emphatic victory, and McClellan finally departed the scene.